tar of the creature. A 21 feet-deep pool was constructed to ensure that the audience was convinced about how difficult it is for the couple to make their way out.

TYM is, of course, not the first Indian film to feature a crocodile as a nemesis. Rekha-starring revenge drama *Khoon Bhari Maang* (*KBM*, 1988) generated genuine dread for the animal and captivated both young and old. Nambiar says there was no mention of the film in Abhishek Bandekar's script but he wanted to reference it to "have fun" with the story while also paying a homage. Luckily for him, *KBM* filmmaker Rakesh Roshan was sweet enough to quickly give the necessary rights.

Whether *TYM* becomes the rage among Gen Z that *KBM* was for millennials remains to be seen, but the makers hope the young take to the love story "with a twist" and "a tinge of horror". That it comes in cinemas on Valentine's Day is a cruel albeit intended coincidence. ■

—Suhani Singh



CLASSICAL FLOURISH *Rama Vaidyanathan and her troupe perform Bharatanatyam at Spectrum 2026, Jan. 30*

NARENDRA DANGIYA

CULTURE ▼

Performing the Body

The Spectrum Dance Festival and Nrityagurukul initiatives by the National Centre for the Performing Arts embrace the entire spectrum of movement—from classical to contemporary

At a time when Indian classical dance often survives on personal sacrifice rather than sustained institutional support, the National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) in Mumbai has been steadily building a dance ecosystem that addresses visibility and continuity. Two of its key initiatives this season, Spectrum and Nrityagurukul, reflect a curatorial philosophy that looks at both the present and the future of dance in India.

Spectrum was conceived as a festival that embraces the entire spectrum of movement, bringing together classical, folk, contemporary and international dance within a single curatorial frame. According to Swapnokalpa Dasgupta, head of dance programming at the NCPA, this inclusivity was never an afterthought. "Because the intent started with presenting the entire spectrum of dance, it was never really a challenge. In fact, that is the challenge we took."

RATHER THAN COMPRESSING PERFORMANCES INTO A SHORT BURST, SPECTRUM IS SPACED ACROSS MULTIPLE DATES, ALLOWING TIME TO RETURN AND EXPLORE UNFAMILIAR FORMS

Rather than compressing performances into a short burst, Spectrum is spaced across multiple dates, allowing audiences time to return and explore various unfamiliar forms.

This year's Spectrum brings together Odissi by Ratikant Mohapatra's Srjan, Kathak by Shama Bhate's Nadroop and the Swiss contemporary work BRICKS, reflecting the festival's commitment to dialogue across classical and international movement practices.

Running alongside is Nrityagurukul, an initiative rooted in the *guru-shishya parampara*. Rather than focusing on short-term training, it supports dancers committed to performance and teaching. "Dance traditions in India are already shaped," Dasgupta says. "What we do not have are opportunities." Nrityagurukul presents Odissi, Manipuri, Kathak and Bharatanatyam through the *guru-shishya* lineages of Ratikant Mohapatra, Priti Patel, Surupa Sen, Piyal Bhattacharya, Shama Bhate and Rama Vaidyanathan, foregrounding mentorship as a living artistic practice while offering a professional platform at the NCPA.

For young dancers, such opportunities can be career-defining. "What the NCPA aims to do is provide consistent institutional support so that those who have already devoted themselves do not drop off, and those who are waiting to commit feel encouraged," Dasgupta says. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

(Spectrum 2026 will continue at the ***NCPA, Mumbai*** *on Feb. 14 & 22. Nrityagurukul 2025–26 will take place on Feb. 16, 17 & 19)*